

A COLLECTOR OF SIGHS

Why are pleasure and punishment so closely related? Hanif Kureishi returns at full throttle.



SOMETHING TO TELL YOU

by HANIF KUREISHI

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■ By Brinda Bose

I am no longer young, and not yet old. I have reached the age of wondering how I will live, and what I will do, with my remaining time and desire... I am not, I feel certain, finished with love, either in its benign or disorderly form, nor it with me." If there are any among you who are brave enough to own up to impending middle age and its accompanying anxieties, then Hanif Kureishi's latest cogitations—on love and desire, violence and guilt, boredom and the manic panic about what the flow of time does to our bodies and minds—are for your ultimate reading pleasure. Even if you have not grown up in London, as Kureishi has, and do not identify with the rocking and the rolling—not to speak of the stoning—of its colourful 1970s and '80s, a pleasure it would still be.

For Kureishi has *Something to Tell You*, again, in his own particular brand of Londonstani, so to speak, well-loved by those intrepid devourers of diaspora who are not satisfied by the mush of nostalgia but like to gnaw at its bones and sinews, as Kureishi's rough yet frangible prose continually exposes. Fans of *The Buddha of Suburbia* will be pleased to re-discover much of the same grittiness here. Those who remember his Oscar-winning screenplay *My Beautiful Laundrette* will be struck by *deja vu* upon finding its young, gay Pakistani hero, Omar, reincarnated here as the paunchy Lord Omar Ali, older and oilier, a successful gay laundrette-chain entre-

preneur. Though Ali—memorable only if you recall his youthful avatar in passionate cinches with a very charismatic Daniel Day Lewis in the 1985 film—is a dispensable minor character in this racy urbanscape of quirky, murky Londoners.

Its heroine may well have been the narrator's sister Miriam, an overweight single mother with a face pierced in so many places that "parts of it resemble a curtain rail", who rules over a semi-criminal family cramped in a council house with a delectable absence of inhibition. The hero could equally have been his dissolute intellectual friend Henry, a rakish yet priggish lapsed theatre director, who discovers his wildest sexual fantasies fulfilled in the unlikely arms of Miriam, a pairing that the narrator labels "almost an incest", so intimately linked are both to him. Or it could have been the ghost of a first love, Ajita, that broods over all his passions and perturbations, a phantasma even while she palely loiters through much

of the tale in person.

Its ageing hero-narrator, however, is Jamal, a second-generation Pakistani-British, established, distinguished, cultured, Freud-spewing psychoanalyst who came of age in London during those heady, hedonistic decades of freedom for the young and the restless, who were often drugged, delinquent and delirious. He is both "a collector of sighs" and a compendium of whispers, for he gathers tales and likes to tell them: sometimes as infamous case studies of his patients, and otherwise as first-person narratives of his life and times, because he believes that he has something to tell you. And tell you he does, painting vivid, prurient pictures of his family and other animals, startling you afresh with evidence of how sex has—always, staggeringly—remained the epicentre of all human machinations. And he has secrets, too: of violence, and a guilt that stalks him incessantly. Jamal ruminates philosophically, "The secrets of why love is difficult, sex complicated,

living painful and death so close... Why are pleasure and punishment closely related? How do our bodies speak? Why do you want to fail? Why is pleasure hard to bear?"

These celebrations are interspersed liberally with the pungent efflux of sex-drug-and-rock-and-rollers, and sprinkled over with Freud, Lacan, Nietzsche, Plaf, Plath, Emerson, Thatcher, Blair, Bush, Mick Jagger and Lauryn Hill, slotting the book both intellectually and historically, running as it does right till the 7/7 blasts of 2005 in central London. What redeems it is Kureishi's ironic distance from his narrator, rehearsing his ribald revelations with a raunchy, wit. A vintage Kureishi certainly gives jaded Londonstan another innings in this one. ■

